

U.S. UNDERGRADUATE HEALTH SCIENCE

Curriculum Trends for Program Renewal

A concise benchmarking brief for faculty reviewing health science, pre-health, public health, and interdisciplinary health curricula.

SAMPLE

8 U.S. universities with official catalog or program pages

USE CASE

Faculty curriculum planning and trend alignment

OUTPUT

Key judgments, comparison matrix, and adoption roadmap

Key Judgments

The most competitive undergraduate health science curricula are moving from broad pre-professional preparation toward applied, evidence-based, systems-aware programs with visible pathways and portfolio-worthy experiences.

- 01 Flexible pathway architecture is now a core design pattern.** Strong programs let students align the major with pre-clinical, public/community health, rehabilitation, health technology, or healthcare management pathways without losing a shared foundation.
 - 02 Applied learning has become a credibility marker.** Co-op, internship, fieldwork, service learning, capstone, and portfolio structures increasingly demonstrate readiness beyond course completion.
 - 03 Health systems literacy is moving into the major core.** Public health, policy, ethics, healthcare delivery, quality, and equity topics are no longer peripheral electives.
 - 04 Research and data literacy are expanding.** Research methods, statistics, epidemiology, informatics, and digital health bridge biomedical foundations and real-world decisions.
 - 05 Interprofessional and community-facing competencies differentiate programs.** Team-based and community-engaged learning connect technical preparation with practice.
 - 06 Microcredentials are emerging as practical add-ons.** Short certification experiences help students leave the major with visible skills and employability signals.
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Scope, Sources, and Design Model

Curriculum Scan Scope

This brief reviews eight U.S. undergraduate Health Science / Health Sciences programs using official catalog and program pages. The scan emphasizes degree structure, core domains, experiential learning, capstone/research requirements, tracks, and distinctive trend signals.

Design Patterns Applied

Stanford HAI: top-takeaway framing, policy highlights, and evidence visualization.

MIT Work of the Future: strong institutional cover, chapter-like sectioning, and generous white space.

Harvard Belfer Center: policy report logic that foregrounds key judgments before narrative evidence.

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Programs reviewed

6

Trend themes coded

3

Implementation horizons

1

Faculty roadmap

The redesigned format prioritizes faculty decision-making: key judgments first, then evidence, then practical adoption steps.

Evidence Rules

- Official university catalog and program pages were prioritized over secondary summaries.
- Items are trend signals, not universal national findings.
- Program details should be rechecked before formal curriculum proposal drafting.

What the Stronger Programs Have in Common

1. A shared foundation plus visible pathways

Programs increasingly combine a common health science foundation with tracks or concentrations. This lets students see a coherent route into clinical preparation, community health, public health, health administration, rehabilitation, or technology-oriented roles.

2. Applied learning as a program promise

Internship, co-op, service learning, and capstone experiences make the curriculum legible to students, graduate programs, and employers. These elements are strongest when scaffolded by research methods, statistics, and communication courses.

3. Systems, equity, and ethics as required literacy

Health science majors are moving beyond anatomy, physiology, and prerequisites. Competitive curricula include health systems, population health, public policy, ethics, quality, safety, and health equity.

4. Data and research readiness

Research methods, epidemiology, statistics, informatics, and digital health are emerging as the analytic backbone of health science education.

Comparison Matrix

Institution	Program Structure	Curriculum Signals	Useful Adaptation
University of Florida	Bachelor of Health Science, 120 credits, four specializations	SLO/curriculum map, capstone portfolio/exam, public health core	Connect program outcomes to a course map and formal capstone assessment.
Drexel University	BS Health Sciences, 183 quarter credits, one co-op option	Six-month co-op, research methods, statistics, ethics, public health, simulation	Position fieldwork as a graduation requirement or high-value restricted elective.
Ohio State University	BS Health Sciences, professional curriculum plus required minor	Pathophysiology, epidemiology, research, healthcare statistics, ethics, management	Use a required or recommended minor to preserve career flexibility.
DePaul University	BS Health Sciences, Bioscience and Public Health Sciences concentrations	Capstone, health ethics, public health, policy, multiple accelerated pathways	Explore undergraduate-to-graduate accelerated pathway options.
University of Minnesota Rochester	BSHS, six focus areas	Health technology, public health, mental health, personalized capstone	Introduce a capstone proposal plus final reflection sequence.
Stockton University	BSHS, General / Pre-PA / Pre-OT / Pre-PT concentrations	IPEC foundation, informatics, service-learning ethics/teamwork, research	Use interprofessional collaborative practice as a program identity.
University of Central Florida	BS Health Sciences, Pre-Clinical and Health Promotion tracks	Research methods, pharmacology, epidemiology, 80-hour internship	Offer an 80+ hour field experience as a 3-credit restricted elective.
Quinnipiac University	BS Health Science Studies	EMT, Mental Health First Aid, microcredentials, IPE, Health Equity minor	Pair short credential modules with curricular or co-curricular portfolios.

The matrix compresses curriculum signals for planning; it is not a full course-by-course equivalency audit.

Curriculum Renewal Roadmap

The highest-value changes can be staged. Start with low-friction modules, then build pathway and capstone architecture once faculty consensus is stronger.

One-Semester Pilots

- Add a Health Systems, Policy, and Ethics module to an existing major course.
- Add Health Data Literacy cases combining statistics, epidemiology, digital health, and AI/data interpretation.
- Convert one lecture into an interprofessional team-based case assignment.

One-Year Revisions

- Create a capstone menu: research, internship, community project, or portfolio.
- Launch two or three tracks: Pre-Clinical, Public/Community Health, Health Data and Technology, Rehabilitation/Exercise, or Healthcare Management.
- Make research methods, statistics, epidemiology, or informatics visible in required coursework.

Program-Level Changes

- Map health equity, interprofessional collaboration, communication, and evidence-based practice to program outcomes.
- Expand fieldwork beyond hospital shadowing to community health, nonprofits, health technology, research labs, and public health agencies.
- Add microcredential or certificate elements tied to student portfolios.

Practical sequence: pilot a module, gather student artifacts, align faculty around learning outcomes, then scale into track or capstone requirements.

Caveats

- The sample size is limited, so the findings should be read as benchmarking signals rather than a national generalization.
- Some institutions provide more detail on program pages than in catalog pages; both were used when official.
- Credit requirements, prerequisites, and graduation rules can change annually. Recheck current catalogs before drafting a formal revision proposal.

Official Curriculum Sources

University of Florida Catalog

catalog.ufl.edu/UGRD/colleges-schools/UGPBH/HES_BHS/

Drexel University Catalog

catalog.drexel.edu/undergraduate/collegeofnursingandhealthprofessions/healthsciences/

Ohio State University

hrs.osu.edu/academics/undergraduate-programs/health-sciences/curriculum

DePaul University Catalog

catalog.depaul.edu/programs/health-sciences-bs/

University of Minnesota Rochester

r.umn.edu/academics/undergraduate-programs/bachelor-science-health-sciences

Stockton University

stockton.edu/health-sciences/health-science.html

University of Central Florida

healthprofessions.ucf.edu/healthsciences/bachelors/

Quinnipiac University

qu.edu/schools/health-sciences/programs/bachelors-degree/health-science-studies/

Design References

Stanford HAI, 2025 AI Index Report and Policy Highlights

hai.stanford.edu/ai-index/2025-ai-index-report

MIT Work of the Future report

workofthefuture-taskforce.mit.edu/research-post/the-work-of-the-future-building-better-jobs-in-an-age-of-intelligent-machines/

Harvard Kennedy School Belfer Center report page

belfercenter.org/research-analysis/eye-storm-pakistans-balancing-act-evolving-geopolitical-order